

CHAPTER FOUR

THE SECRETS OF EXPERIENCE: WISDOM BEYOND DEMONSTRATION

Although everybody has them, ‘experiences’ belong to the concepts that are most difficult to define and apply academically.¹ In a long and complex discussion, philosophy, sociology, psychology, neurology, theology, and the academic study of religion have established a multitude of models that aim at understanding and interpreting what is actually going on when people have experiences. When it comes to ‘religious experience’ the discussion is even trickier because theological and ideological normativities are entering in, along with subjective categories that are difficult to standardize or catalogue.

Ever since the nineteenth century, and particularly after William James’ *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study in Human Nature* (1902), the category ‘religious experience’ has been closely related to the category ‘mysticism.’² Mystical experience has repeatedly been described as an individual encounter with the divine by means of dissolution of boundaries, be they physiological, categorial, or emotional. From a scholarly point of view, the major academic problem with mysticism and experience, then, is the fact that the experiences themselves are inaccessible for unambiguous academic scrutiny, particularly if we leave the experimental frameworks of analysis and turn to historical sources.³ These sources are texts, images, or material objects that *communicate* and—in the case of texts—*report* mystical experiences. Consequently, research into experience and mysticism has turned to issues of *narrativity* and *social construction* in order to explain the dynamics of religious experience, thus leaving behind earlier ontological or

¹ See the overview in Sharf, “Experience.”

² See Wilke, “Mysticism.” A search on “experi* AND mysti*” in the university library database of the Netherlands rendered 677 titles in July 2008. A Google search on “mysticism AND experience” gave more than 2,700,000 hits. In October 2009 the numbers were 707 and 1,980,000, respectively.

³ This does not mean, of course, that the results of cognitive science or experimental psychology cannot be applied profitably to historical issues. But even then our analysis is limited by the narrative nature of most sources, with the exception of visual sources, such as analyzed in chapter 8 below.